

KEY TACTIC

KAMIKAZE

1944–45

In October 1944, Japan began to adopt suicide tactics, deliberately crashing their aircraft into American ships with the aim of crippling or sinking them. The kamikaze (“divine wind”) units were initially made up of only elite flyers, but, by 1945, suicide attack had become a task for thousands of poorly trained novice pilots. An estimated 322 Allied ships were hit by kamikaze planes, and at least 34 of them sank.



▲ A Japanese Zero fighter seen just before it crashed into the USS *Missouri*, in 1945. The battleship suffered only superficial damage.

► THE DIVE-BOMBER

One of a new generation of high-performance American carrier aircraft introduced during World War II, the Curtiss SB2C Helldiver could bomb accurately enough to hit ships, unlike most conventional bombers.



KEY DEVELOPMENT

AIR AND SEA BATTLES

The growth of air power between 1914 and 1945 transformed naval warfare. Capable of deciding the outcome of battles with the long-range strike power of their aircraft, carriers took over from battleships as the most potent warships in a fleet.



▲ THE FAIREY SWORDFISH

The UK entered World War II with the outdated Fairey Swordfish biplane as its torpedo bomber. The slow-flying “Stringbag” was surprisingly effective, notably in an attack on the Italian fleet at Taranto in 1940.

Navies were at the forefront of the early development of military aviation. Naval commanders could see the advantages of aerial reconnaissance and were quick to experiment with both aeroplanes and airships when war broke out in 1914.

At first, seaplane tenders carried float aircraft, which were winched over the side to take off from the sea and – hopefully – recovered from the sea after returning from their mission. In 1916, the British Royal Navy began replacing

seaplanes with wheeled landplanes. These might take off from a platform mounted on a warship’s revolving gun turret or from a raft towed behind a destroyer. To land, these light, canvas-and-wood aircraft simply ditched into the sea, and were then hoisted aboard the ship.

In 1917, the British cruiser HMS *Furious* was fitted with a long flight deck, on which landing trials were carried out with a Sopwith Pup biplane. A converted ocean liner, HMS *Argus*, came closer to achieving a successful aircraft carrier design, recognizing the need to avoid